

The other factors

Apart from this, the rest is as usual in Fedora-land. Fedora 14 includes Linux 2.6.35, which has nice desktop-oriented improvements. KDE 4.5 is beautiful. For GNOME, we need to wait until version 3 to see how it fares. Adobe killed Flash 10.1 for 64-bit Linux, but its pre-release 10.2 works correctly. KDE's Network Manager is getting better. Bluetooth still needs improvement in KDE; Kubuntu has included BlueDevil as the Bluetooth tool, but it doesn't work correctly in Fedora 14. KBluetooth does, if you are careful! Another problem is that Skype does not work on 64-bit Fedora (it does in Ubuntu, but not here in Fedora); but by the error message, it seems that the problem is caused by Skype itself, or its packaging and not by Fedora. The correct dependencies for running the 32 bit version on a 64 bit system have not been included so the application cannot find the 32 bit libraries it needs and thus fails to start. Anyway, Skype only releases beta versions for GNU/Linux—and even then, they are only tested on hopelessly outdated versions of the distributions they release for. Jabber and Google Talk/Gmail video chat are better alternatives.

The verdict

Fedora has earned itself a reputation as a lab for enterprise features, but it seems the Fedora developers are now serious about solid, user-friendly desktop software. Fedora 14 also has its share of new enterprise features, such as the OpenSCAP security system, and the Spice virtualisation framework, but the new, user-oriented website and the excellent desktop systems give Fedora both a highly professional look, and the feel of a really good desktop operating system.

One gripe is that Fedora KDE bundles up the KDE applications in generic KDE packages (such as *kdemultimedia*); it would be much better if they'd been split into individual packages, as with Kubuntu. For example, I don't need JuK or Dragon Player, but I have to keep them because I need KMix. Another is that although double-tapping the laptop touch-pad works as a double-click in Qt applications, it doesn't in the case of GTK apps running in KDE; I have to double-click the button for that. Still, what matters is, as I said earlier, the diligence with which the Fedora developers prepare their distribution. Fedora often misses deadlines, but that is thousands of times better than releasing a buggy product. Kubuntu 10.10, for example, also includes KDE 4.5, but both Ubuntu and Kubuntu 10.10 (and, I suspect, all derivatives) freeze randomly on some computers, including mine. There was a mad rush to release on 10/10/10 at 10:10:10 GMT. They met the deadline, but tripped while trying to run.

In version 4, KDE redefined desktop computing. It's been a long time since I last used it. I don't know whether Fedora will keep up this dedication to the desktop; I hope it does! As for KDE, well, the oldest major desktop environment for one of the oldest operating systems is now the most modern (at least until GNOME 3 arrives, and who knows what bugs



Figure 11: Live video thumbnails on the taskbar



Figure 12: Handling file name conflicts in Nautilus

it will bring along), riding one of the most advanced and fastest-growing operating systems. For now, it seems, I'm back home. 

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